

CAMBRIDGE O LEVEL ENGLISH LANGUAGE 1123

Teacher-Prepared CAIE-Style Mark Scheme

TEXT A: THE FORGOTTEN OBSERVATORY

Question 1: Comprehension | Question 2: Use of Language

QUESTION 1 16 marks	QUESTION 2 9 marks	TOTAL 25 marks
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Important: This is a teacher-prepared practice mark scheme modelled on current Cambridge marking conventions. It is not an official Cambridge publication.

GENERAL MARKING GUIDANCE

Apply these principles consistently across all responses.

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|---|---|
| 1 | Award whole marks only. |
| 2 | Credit alternative answers that communicate the same meaning clearly. |
| 3 | Do not require perfect spelling or grammar unless an error makes the meaning unclear. |
| 4 | Where the question requires own words, do not credit an answer that merely repeats the key words from the passage. |
| 5 | For supporting details, accurate quotations are acceptable unless own words are specifically required. |
| 6 | Do not award additional marks for repetition of the same idea. |
| 7 | In Question 2, naming a technique such as simile, metaphor or personification is not sufficient; the candidate must explain the effect created. |

QUESTION 1: COMPREHENSION

Assessment objectives: R1 explicit meaning and R2 implicit meaning and attitudes.

Question 1(a)**[1]**

From paragraph 1, identify one detail which suggests that the observatory has been neglected.

EXPECTED ANSWER

It is “streaked with rust and moss”.

ALLOW

- rust covering or marking the dome
- moss growing on the dome
- the dome is rusty
- the dome has rust and moss on it

DO NOT ALLOW

- it is going to be demolished
- it is almost invisible in the rain
- it looks like a stranded ship
- it is abandoned (this comes from the introduction, not paragraph 1)

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

This is an explicit retrieval question. Candidates must locate one visible sign that the building has not been properly maintained.

Question 1(b)**[2]**

Using your own words, explain what the text means when it says Grandad “attacked hills as if they had personally insulted him”.

EXPECTED ANSWER

Grandad climbed hills with great energy and determination, treating each hill as a personal challenge that he was determined to defeat.

MARKING

- 1 mark: he climbed forcefully, energetically or determinedly.
- 1 mark: he regarded the hills as challenges or opponents that had to be conquered.

ALLOW

- he charged up hills
- he tackled hills energetically
- he climbed with fierce determination
- he treated each hill as an enemy
- he was determined not to let a hill defeat him

DO NOT ALLOW

- he attacked the hills because they insulted him
- he was angry with the hills
- the hills had spoken rudely to him
- he climbed hills (too general for two marks)

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must unpack both parts of the image. Grandad does not literally attack hills; the expression shows his competitive and forceful approach to climbing.

Question 1(c)(i)**[1]**

In paragraph 4, what does Grandad discover when he brushes dust from the hand-wheel?

EXPECTED ANSWER

The two sets of initials “E.M.” and “S.R.” scratched into the paint.

ALLOW

- E.M. and S.R.
- his and Sofia’s initials
- two sets of initials scratched into the wheel

DO NOT ALLOW

- writing on the wheel
- some letters
- dust
- a message from Sofia

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

This is a straightforward explicit-detail question requiring accurate selection from paragraph 4.

Question 1(c)(ii)**[1]**

Why does Grandad quickly cover this discovery with his palm?

EXPECTED ANSWER

He wants to hide the initials because they are connected to a private and emotionally painful memory of Sofia.

ALLOW

- he does not want Mara to notice or question them
- they remind him of Sofia and their past
- he wants to conceal his personal connection with the observatory
- he is not yet ready to explain their significance

DO NOT ALLOW

- he wants to clean the wheel
- he wants to protect the initials from dust
- he is hiding damage to the wheel
- the initials are illegal
- he is simply embarrassed, without explanation

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must infer the reason for Grandad’s movement. His quick action suggests that the initials have personal significance which he is not ready to discuss.

Question 1(d)**[1]**

Explain what Mara has noticed that makes her feel that the machine has “been waiting for him”.

EXPECTED ANSWER

Grandad’s familiarity with the observatory and his reaction to the initials show that he has an important past connection with the machine.

ALLOW

- the initials suggest that Grandad used the machine in the past
- Grandad clearly remembers the observatory and knows his way around it
- he immediately recognises and hides the initials
- his behaviour suggests he has returned to something connected with his past

DO NOT ALLOW

- the machine is patient
- the telescope is old
- it has been standing there for a long time
- the machine actually knows Grandad
- the telescope is aimed at the roof

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Mara interprets the telescope as though it were alive because Grandad behaves like someone returning to a familiar and meaningful place.

Question 1(e)**[3]**

In paragraph 6, how does Grandad feel after he snaps at Mara? Give two details from the text to support your answer.

EXPECTED ANSWER

Grandad feels regretful, remorseful, ashamed, apologetic or embarrassed by his angry reaction.

MARKING

- 1 mark for an appropriate feeling.
- 1 mark for each of two relevant supporting details: “his shoulders sagged”; “Not yet, anyway”; “attempting a smile”; “a smile that arrived too late”; or “the words hung between us” if linked clearly to discomfort.

ALLOW

- sorry
- guilty
- uncomfortable
- ashamed
- disappointed in himself

DO NOT ALLOW

- angry
- furious
- happy
- amused
- tired
- weak
- “I’m not made of glass”; “he shook me off”; “he snapped” as evidence, because these show the earlier anger

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must infer Grandad’s changed feeling and support it with two precise details showing his physical and verbal attempt to repair the situation.

EXAMINER NOTE

Full-mark example: Grandad feels regretful. His “shoulders sagged”, and he attempted “a smile that arrived too late”.

Question 1(f)**[2]**

Explain what Grandad is thinking when he takes the notebook “as carefully as if it were alive”.

EXPECTED ANSWER

He considers the notebook extremely precious because it contains Sofia’s work and memories, and he believes it is fragile and must be protected from further damage.

MARKING

- 1 mark: the notebook is precious or emotionally important to him.
- 1 mark: it is fragile or vulnerable and must be handled carefully.

ALLOW

- it is a treasured reminder of Sofia
- it contains evidence of Sofia’s achievement
- it preserves an important part of his past
- it is almost like a living connection to his wife
- it has been damaged by damp and could fall apart

DO NOT ALLOW

- he thinks the notebook is actually alive
- he believes it can move
- he is frightened of it
- there is an animal inside it
- he is only interested because it contains scientific information

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

The simile shows both the notebook’s physical delicacy and its emotional significance. To Grandad, it almost preserves Sofia’s living presence.

Question 1(g)**[2]**

From paragraph 8, give two details which show why Grandad believes Sofia deserved recognition for the discovery.

EXPECTED ANSWER

- Sofia was “brilliant”.
- She “had noticed the comet before anyone else”.

ALLOW

- she was highly intelligent or talented
- she was the first person to observe the comet
- she made the actual discovery
- Grandad argued so strongly for her recognition that he was threatened with dismissal, if used as evidence of his belief

DO NOT ALLOW

- she was a young assistant
- she was rarely taken seriously
- the report carried the director’s name
- she later became Grandad’s wife
- her initials were on the wheel

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must distinguish evidence that Sofia deserved recognition from evidence that she did not receive it. Her intelligence and first sighting establish her entitlement to credit.

Question 1(h)**[3]**

Explain using your own words Mara's different feelings during the visit to the observatory. Give three details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

MARKING

- Award 1 mark for each valid combination of an appropriate feeling expressed in the candidate's own words and a relevant supporting detail.
- Maximum 3 marks. Three synonyms for the same feeling should not receive three separate marks.

Mara's feeling	Relevant supporting detail
Reluctant, irritated or unenthusiastic	She had left a warm room and unfinished homework.
Annoyed or uncomfortable	The rain kept finding a new way through her coat.
Doubtful about the purpose of the visit	She wondered why anyone would climb there to rescue "a few papers".
Concerned or protective towards Grandad	Mum had asked her to keep an eye on him.
Worried about his health	He stopped twice to catch his breath.
Protective	She joined him mainly to prevent him hurting himself.
Alarmed or concerned	She caught his arm when he stumbled.
Surprised or intrigued	Grandad moved with "surprising certainty"; she felt the machine had been waiting for him.
Hurt or uncomfortable	His angry words "hung between us".
Fascinated by Grandma	She saw impatience in the crossings-out and excitement in the handwriting.
Moved or sympathetic	Grandad had not entered the dome since Sofia's death.
Trusted or responsible	Grandad let her carry the brass key and did not ask for it back.
Awed and respectful	She sees the dome as "not forgotten, but watchful".

FULL-MARK EXAMPLE

At first, Mara is irritated and reluctant, as she has left a warm room and unfinished homework. She then becomes concerned for Grandad, joining him to stop him from hurting himself. By the end, she feels trusted and emotionally connected to the observatory, shown when she carries the key down the hill and Grandad does not ask for it back.

ALLOW

- accurate paraphrases of supporting details
- direct quotations as evidence
- other plausible feelings firmly supported by the text

DO NOT ALLOW

- three quotations without identifying Mara's feelings
- three feelings without textual support
- feelings belonging to Grandad or Sofia
- three synonyms for the same emotion
- retelling the events without inference

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must trace how Mara's attitude develops. She moves from seeing the journey as an inconvenient task to understanding the observatory's emotional and historical importance.

QUESTION 2: USE OF LANGUAGE

Assessment objective: R4 - explain how writers achieve effects and influence readers.

QUESTION 2 REMINDER

Candidates must explain suggestions, associations and impressions created by particular words and images. Naming a device without analysing its effect is not enough.

Question 2(a)

[2]

What two impressions does the writer want to convey about the observatory and its telescope in this extract?

EXPECTED ANSWER

- The observatory seems alive, as though it responds to the storm.
- It appears old, fragile or unstable because it shudders and trembles.
- The telescope appears patient and expectant, as though it has waited for someone to return.
- The telescope seems powerful or imposing because it is enormous.
- The sealed roof makes it seem trapped or unable to perform its purpose.

MARKING

Award 1 mark for each distinct and text-rooted impression, up to 2 marks.

ALLOW

- old and vulnerable
- alive and responsive
- eerie or threatening atmosphere
- dignified and expectant
- dormant or imprisoned

DO NOT ALLOW

- there is thunder
- the building is made of metal
- the telescope is under a grey cover
- the writer uses personification, without explaining the effect

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

The writer turns the building and telescope into almost living beings. The observatory reacts physically, while the telescope waits silently and patiently.

EXAMINER NOTE

Full-mark example: The observatory seems like an old living creature that shakes when the thunder strikes. The telescope appears huge and patient, as though it has been silently waiting to be used again.

Question 2(b)**[2]**

What effect does the writer suggest about the wheel by using the phrase “resisted us like a locked jaw”?

EXPECTED ANSWER

- The wheel is extremely rigid, jammed or tightly clamped and is very difficult to move.
- It appears stubborn, hostile or almost alive, as though it is deliberately refusing to open.

MARKING

Award 1 mark for each distinct effect.

ALLOW

- completely stuck
- tightly closed
- seized up
- very difficult to force open
- stubborn
- uncooperative
- like a person gritting their teeth

DO NOT ALLOW

- the wheel has a jaw
- the wheel is locked (mere repetition)
- the wheel is broken
- it is a simile
- it makes the description interesting

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

A locked jaw is tightly clenched and unwilling to open. The comparison communicates both the wheel’s physical stiffness and its apparently deliberate resistance.

Question 2(c)**[1]**

Explain why the writer uses the word “burst” rather than “entered” in the sentence “Wind burst through the opening”.

EXPECTED ANSWER

“Burst” suggests that the wind entered suddenly and violently or with great force, whereas “entered” would sound calm and neutral.

ALLOW

- it rushed in suddenly
- it forced its way through
- it entered with explosive energy
- it was uncontrolled and powerful

DO NOT ALLOW

- “burst” is a stronger word
- “burst” is more effective
- “entered” is boring
- it makes the reader interested
- the wind came inside

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must compare the connotations of the two words. “Entered” merely describes movement; “burst” adds speed, force and violence.

Question 2(d)**[1]**

What does the writer want to suggest to the reader about Grandad’s feelings at this point in the story?

EXPECTED ANSWER

Grandad regrets snapping at Mara and unsuccessfully tries to soften the tension, while also feeling vulnerable or saddened by his increasing age and weakness.

ALLOW

- he is sorry or ashamed
- he regrets his angry response
- he feels guilty for hurting Mara
- he tries to apologise without directly saying sorry
- he is saddened by becoming physically fragile
- he realises his smile cannot undo what he said

DO NOT ALLOW

- he is happy because he smiles
- he is still furious
- he is making a joke
- he is tired
- he is weak (this describes condition, not feeling)

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

His sagging shoulders show deflation or regret. The delayed smile suggests that he tries to repair the moment but knows that the damage has already been done.

Question 2(e)**[3]**

Identify one example of how the writer uses language effectively to convey Mara’s changed view of the observatory. Explain the impression created.

MARKING

- 1 mark for a precise and relevant example.
- 1 mark for a valid first impression.
- 1 mark for a second, distinct impression.
- The explanation must focus on the selected example.

Example 1: “its unfamiliar weight in my pocket”**Impressions:**

- The key has symbolic weight because it carries Grandad and Sofia’s history.
- Mara now feels responsible for preserving that history.

Allow: the key represents trust; the past is being passed to Mara; the responsibility feels new or serious.

Do not allow: the key is physically very heavy; she is simply not used to carrying keys.

Example 2: “he did not ask for the key”**Impressions:**

- Grandad deliberately lets Mara keep it, showing that he trusts her.
- Responsibility for remembering Sofia and the observatory is being passed to a new generation.

Allow: Mara has inherited the family story; Grandad recognises that Mara now understands.

Do not allow: Grandad forgot about the key; he no longer needs it because the building will be destroyed.

Example 3: “the observatory’s dome caught the moonlight and shone for a moment”**Impressions:**

- The decaying building is briefly transformed into something beautiful and dignified.
- The momentary shine suggests a final revival or farewell before destruction.

Allow: Mara now sees beauty and value in it; it seems to come alive for one final moment.

Do not allow: the moon is bright; the dome merely reflects light.

Example 4: “not rescued, not forgotten, but watchful”**Impressions:**

- The building cannot be physically saved, but its history and importance will continue to be remembered.
- “Watchful” makes it seem alive, like a guardian of the family’s memories.
- Mara no longer sees it as an empty, neglected building.

Allow: its destruction will not erase its history; Sofia’s achievement will be remembered; the observatory becomes a guardian.

Do not allow: someone is literally watching them; the observatory will not be demolished; “watchful” means it has eyes.

FULL-MARK MODEL ANSWER

Example: “not rescued, not forgotten, but watchful”. Although the observatory cannot be saved from demolition, its history and Sofia’s achievement will continue to be remembered. The word “watchful” makes the building appear alive, like a guardian of the family’s memories, showing that Mara now sees it as meaningful rather than abandoned.

EXPLANATION OF THE QUESTION

Candidates must select language rich enough to support two impressions, then analyse how that language reveals Mara’s changed attitude. A literal paraphrase or the name of a technique alone is insufficient.

MARK SUMMARY

Question-by-question allocation for quick checking.

Question	Marks
Question 1(a)	1
Question 1(b)	2
Question 1(c)(i)	1

Question 1(c)(ii)	1
Question 1(d)	1
Question 1(e)	3
Question 1(f)	2
Question 1(g)	2
Question 1(h)	3
Question 1 total	16
Question 2(a)	2
Question 2(b)	2
Question 2(c)	1
Question 2(d)	1
Question 2(e)	3
Question 2 total	9
OVERALL TOTAL	25